



Real Income, Steady Earnings

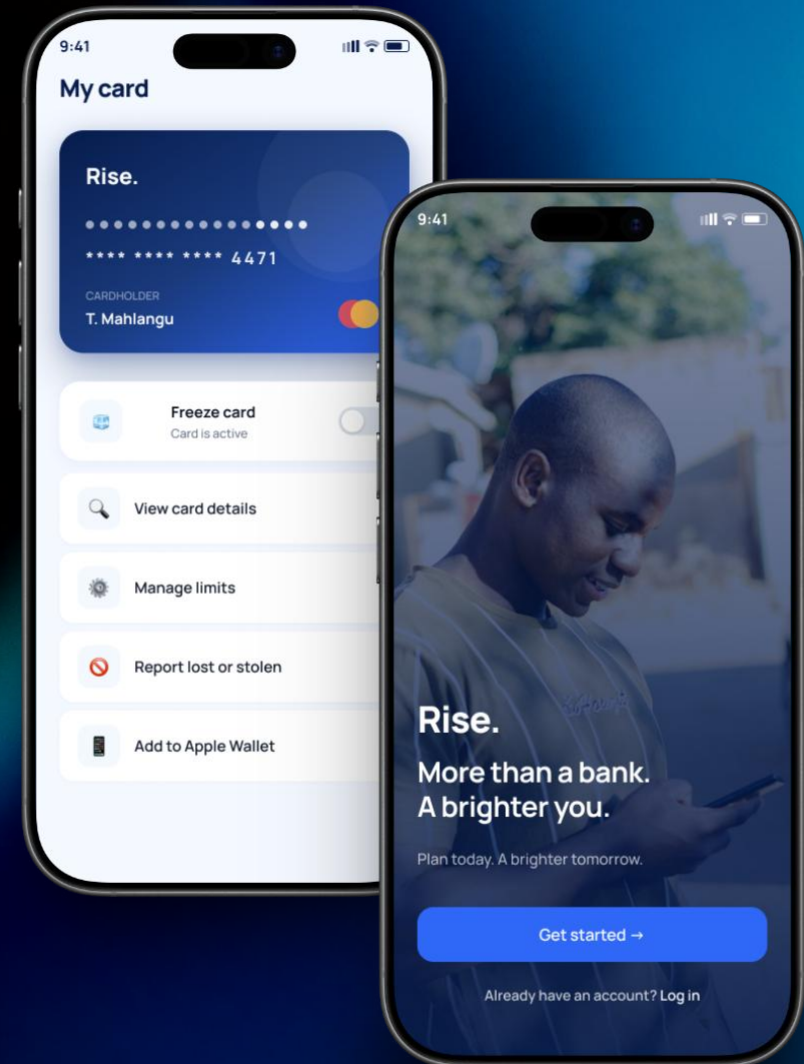
Youth unemployment in South Africa has climbed for a decade from 36.9% in 2015 to 47.4% by Q2 2026. This study explores what happens on the other side of that statistic: not the job search, but the first few months of being paid.

MY ROLE

Individual Contributor, UX Designer

STATUS

Design exploration, not built or shipped



The first-payslip problem looks structural, and one point in the loop is designable

47.4%

CONTEXT

Youth unemployment by Q2 2026. Landing a first job changes the pressure on a young earner; it does not remove it.

3 of 3

INSIGHT

The convergence of three independent signals suggested that the problem may be structural rather than purely behavioural, giving us a hypothesis to test with first-job earners.

5

RESPONSE

Design decisions that protect financial breathing room: a Buffer, a predictive warning, shame-free help and context-first onboarding.

> R0

MEASURE

Success is a buffer that survives to the next payday, not sign-ups or app opens.

Status: design exploration, not built or shipped. Next: test with real first-job earners and stress-test irregular income.

“

I finally have a job. Why do I feel like I'm failing at it before I've even started spending?

Thabo (composite persona), 23 – four months into his first job

Illustrative quote, not a verbatim interview.

Getting the job does not end the pressure, it changes its shape

The hidden cost of looking

Nobody puts the real cost of finding work in the job advert: taxi fares to interviews, data for video calls, CVs printed at an internet café. Thabo made 38 applications, had 3 interviews and one almost-offer that turned out to be a scam before landing his role.

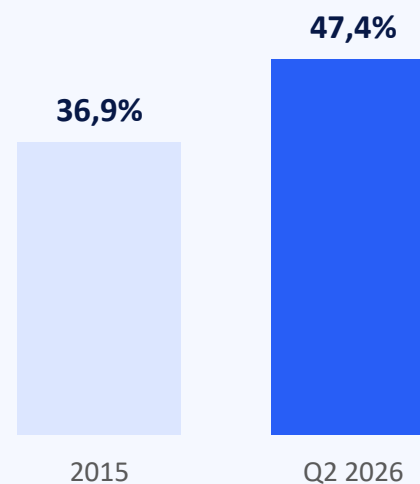
Why the first payslip carries so much weight

Existing youth accounts offer no plan for uncertainty, no place for family obligation, and no way to ask a “stupid” question without shame. Many young people quietly conclude that banks were never for them.

Thabo is a composite persona. His story and the application counts illustrate the pattern from secondary research, not a single interviewee's data.

Youth unemployment rate

South Africa, % of youth labour force



+10.5 pts
in a decade

Thabo's road to a first job

Count, from application to role

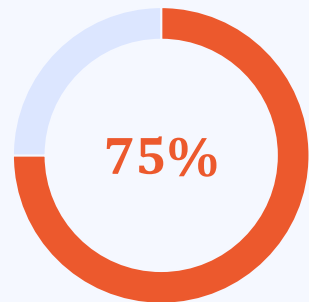


1 in 38
applications ended in a job

Three independent signals point the same way: this looks structural, not just a mindset problem

I chose statistics that could test three different explanations for the same behaviour. If young people were simply “bad with money”, one would be weak and the others fine. All three came back low.

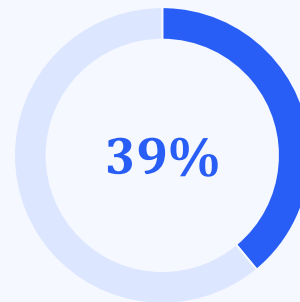
THE EMOTIONAL STATE



of South Africans under 35 report financial anxiety or stress, up 18% year-on-year

Source: Debt Rescue Money Stress Tracker, 2026

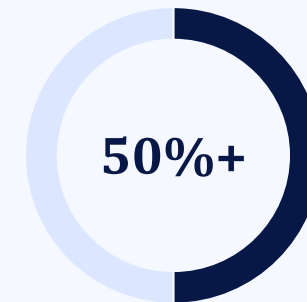
THE SKILLS GAP



feel confident in their own digital financial skills

Source: SA Social Media Landscape report

THE OUTLOOK



say they do not know how to build a stable financial future

Source: Old Mutual Youth Generational Wealth Survey

So what: three angles on one population move “maybe it’s a mindset problem” toward “this looks structural”. Skills and outlook are self-reported, so income and cost-of-living data would strengthen the case.

Thabo does not need a feature-rich banking app; he needs to know he will still be okay



COMPOSITE PERSONA

Thabo Mahlangu

The Cautious Provider

23 · Johannesburg · first job ·
R6,800/month

"If I spend this now, will I still be okay later?"

CORE NEED

Financial breathing room: keeping his buffer above zero.

BEHAVIOURS

Checks balance after payday, debit orders and larger purchases. Always asks: "What will I have left after this?"

DECISION-MAKING

Splits money into transport, home, food and "do not touch". Prefers reversible moves over locked commitments.

FRUSTRATIONS

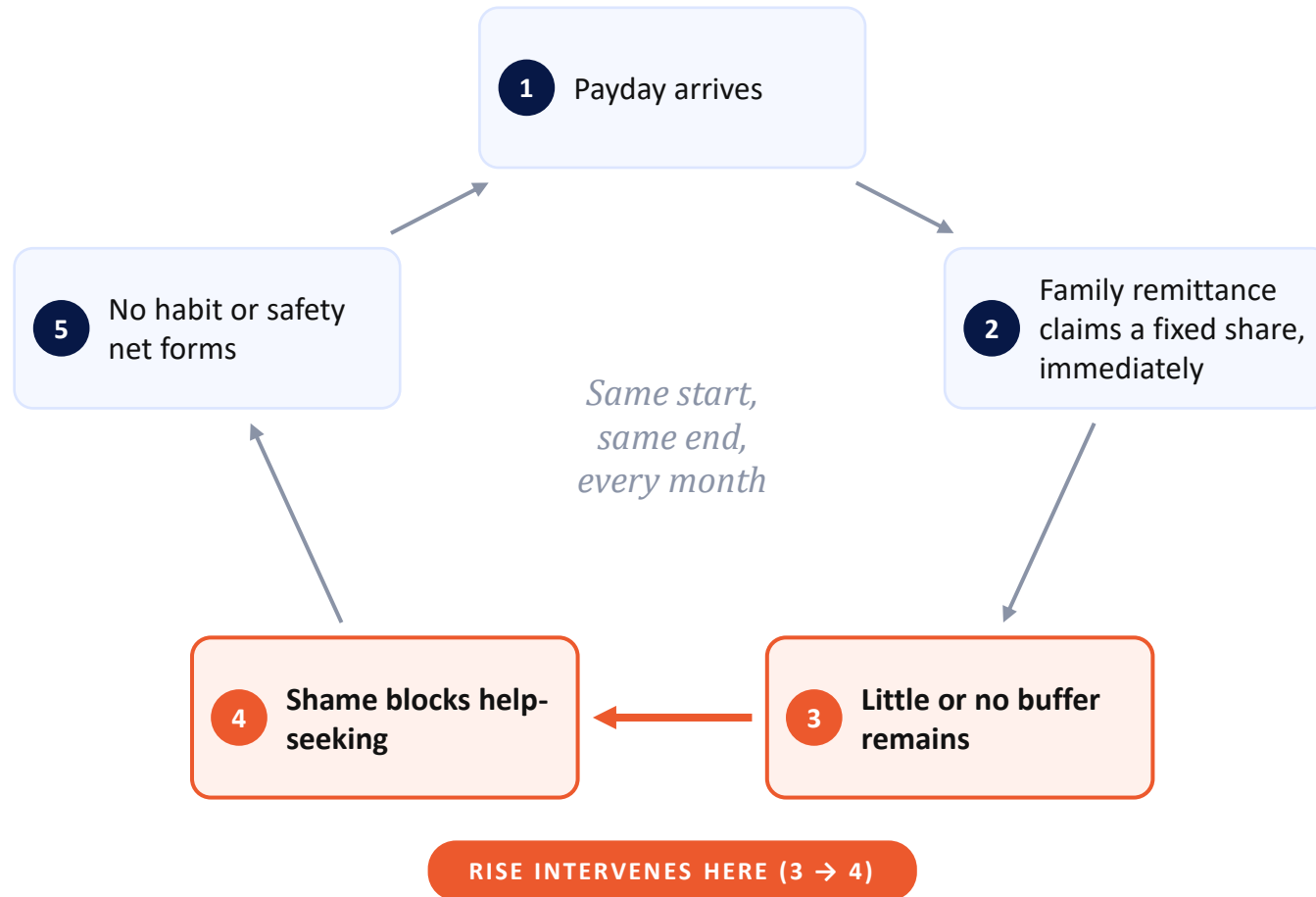
Banks show what happened, not what happens next. Jargon makes him feel judged; surprise deductions break his sense of control.

MOTIVATIONS

Support home without losing progress. Build credit without debt anxiety. End the month with money remaining.

Product implication: prioritise safe-to-spend, upcoming deductions and buffer warnings; design for pressure moments, not only account management.

The problem is a loop, and only one point in it is inside a product's control



Why a loop, not a journey

A linear journey (payday, open the app, adjust a budget) cannot explain why the same problem returns every month. A loop shows that identical starting conditions produce identical outcomes unless something inside it changes. Naming the loop is what lets us choose a deliberate point to interrupt.

The loop is a working hypothesis from secondary research. Family remittance needs validating in interviews.

One point in five is designable

RISE cannot change what family expects or when payroll runs. It can make checking in on money private and judgment-free enough that shame does not get the final word.

Success is a safety net that survives the month, not an account that gets opened

REJECTED

Sign-up rate

How many first-job earners create an account

Easy to inflate with a marketing push; says nothing about whether the payday moment was handled differently.

SECONDARY

App opens on payday

Whether the calm notification gets attention

Shows a habit forming around the moment, but not whether anyone is better off because of it.

PRIMARY

Buffer balance > 0

Whether a safety net survived the month

Directly tests whether the design interrupted the loop. A habit that does not survive to the next payday has not changed anything.

North star: does Thabo still have something in his Buffer the day before his next payslip lands?

Five design decisions, each replacing a banking convention with a response to the loop

DECISION	BARRIER IT ADDRESSES	CONVENTION REJECTED
1 Buffer as a first-class object	Falling below zero with no protected money	A buffer treated as one more savings goal
2 Ask RISE quick-question channel	Embarrassment blocks help-seeking	FAQ, hidden chatbot or support ticketing
3 Money 101 progressive lessons	Jargon; not knowing what to learn	A standalone financial literacy hub
4 Context-first onboarding	Income alone does not show life stage	KYC-first, compliance-heavy sequence
5 Predictive buffer warning	Alerts arrive after the damage is done	Fixed-threshold low-balance alert

Make the Buffer a first-class financial object, not another savings account

DECISION

The Buffer is surfaced in onboarding and throughout the experience as money that protects Thabo from falling below zero.

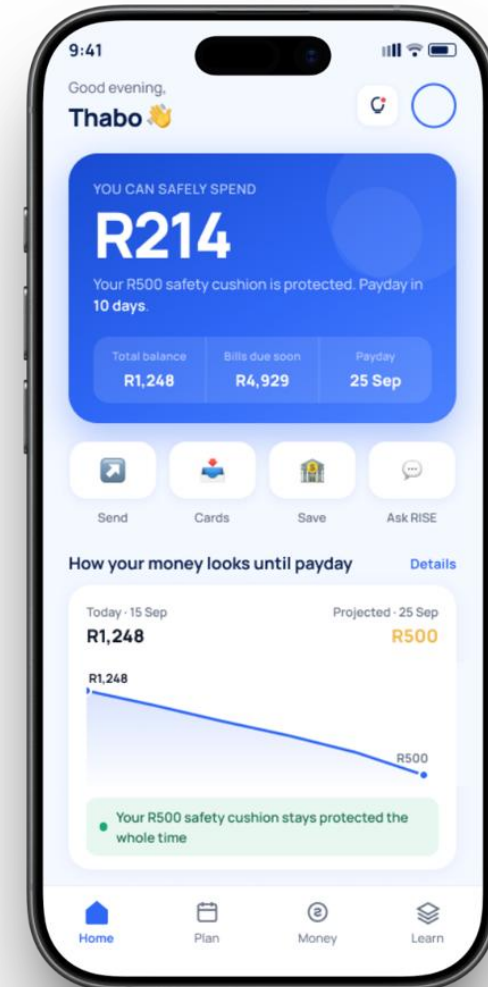
WHY

His measure of progress is not wealth accumulation yet; it is surviving the month with something left. RISE separates money that protects stability from money that funds ambition.

REJECTED

Treating the buffer as a savings goal beside a phone or holiday. It would make an essential safety mechanism compete with aspirations.

[Links to the primary metric:](#) buffer balance above zero.



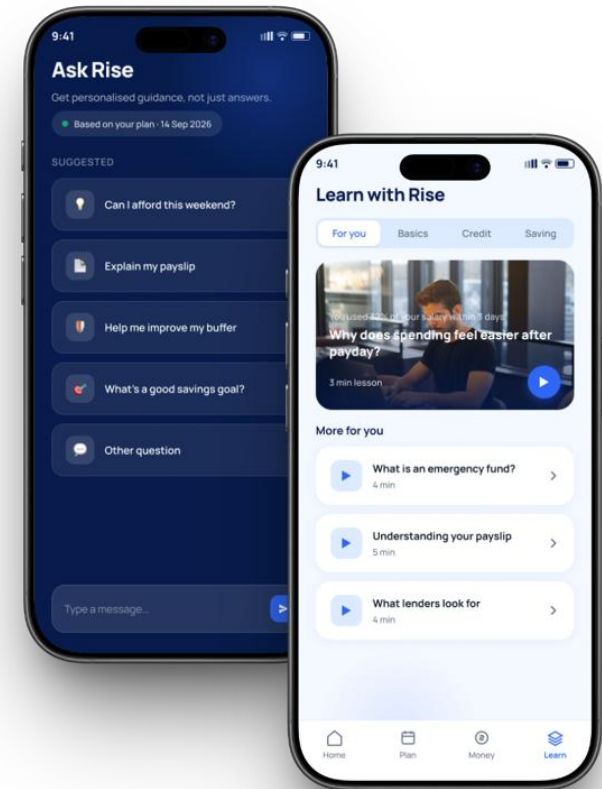
Treat asking for help as normal banking, and learning as support, not homework

Ask RISE: a quick-question channel, not a support ticket

- DECISION** A clear place to ask money questions, with suggested prompts so nobody starts from a blank screen.
- WHY** Embarrassment stops people asking at all (loop point 4), and early on they may lack the terms to search a help centre.
- REJECTED** An FAQ, hidden chatbot or ticketing flow. They optimise support operations, not the psychological barrier.

Money 101: progressive lessons, not a wall of terms

- DECISION** Short lessons that sit alongside everyday banking and connect to decisions a first-job earner is already making.
- WHY** Education works best near the moment of uncertainty and helps a habit and safety net form (loop point 5).
- REJECTED** A literacy hub of articles and definitions. It assumes users know what to learn and are motivated to search.



Help-seeking and learning live inside the app people already use.

Start onboarding with context, not compliance

DECISION

A sequence of lightweight questions about employment stage, income and priorities replaces one dense screen of KYC fields.

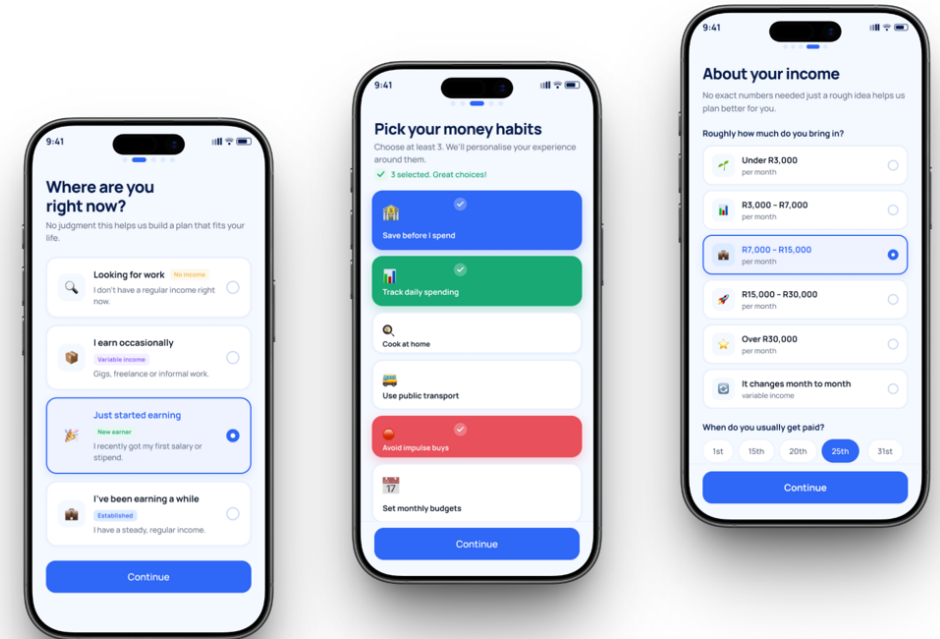
WHY

Income alone does not show stability. A new hire, someone on probation and someone months into a role may earn the same but need very different support.

REJECTED

KYC-first onboarding as the dominant experience. It tells the bank who the customer is, not what financial transition they are navigating.

Effect: RISE understands Thabo's reality before it recommends anything.



Warn before the buffer breaks, not after the balance is gone

DECISION

RISE warns when an action is likely to reduce the protected buffer, showing what may happen next, how much is safe to spend, and how to protect breathing room.

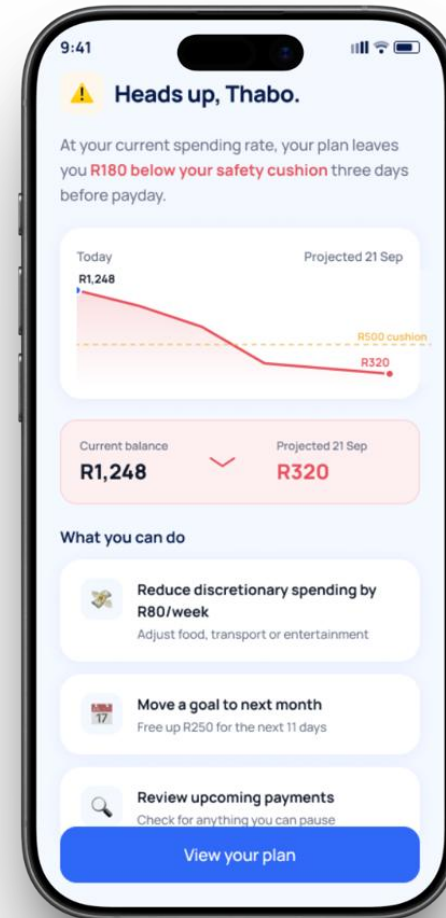
WHY

It turns an alert into a decision-support moment, using the user's own context rather than a fixed number.

REJECTED

A conventional fixed-threshold alert. It reacts too late and ignores upcoming obligations.

Where RISE moves beyond a banking app: RISE predicts when breathing room is about to disappear.



A calm visual language where colour carries meaning

Core Blue #285EF6 Primary actions, selected states	Deep Navy #071846 Ask RISE, focused guidance
Obligation Orange #EC592D Required costs	Risk Red #F14A46 Buffer warning and risk state
Safety Green #008200 Goals, progress, on-track states	Sky Tint #EEF4FF Selected cards, calm surfaces
Ink #111111 Primary text	State Grey #5A5A5A Secondary, supporting text

TYPE SCALE · BASE 16, RATIO 1.25

H160px

H239px

H431px

Text heading24px

Text body20px

Text label16px

RADIUS xs 4 · sm 8 · md 12 · lg 16

Primary

Disabled

What would come after this exploration

01

Test with real first-job earners

Check that the Buffer, the predictive warning and Ask RISE behave as intended outside a prototype.

02

Stress-test irregular income

Everything here assumes a predictable monthly payday. Gig and informal income does not arrive on a schedule, so a design built around “the day it lands” must hold up when that day moves.

03

Measure what matters

The real test is whether Thabo still has something left in Buffer the day before his next payslip lands, not whether he opened the app on payday.

ThankYou

RISE was a self-directed exploration of what real financial support looks like in the first few months after a first paycheck, built from research, not assumption.